FLASHPOINTS & FRAMEWORKS

SYSTEMS UNDER STRAIN: HUNGER, HEALTH SECURITY, STRATEGIC INFRASTRUCTURE, AND THE EXPANDING GEOGRAPHY OF RISK

ARAC INTERNATIONAL WEEKLY GLOBAL SECURITY, CONFLICT SYSTEMS & STRATEGIC RISK REVIEW

WEEK ENDING 24 OCTOBER 2026

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00 Executive Assessment | BLUF

The week ending October 24 is defined less by a single battlefield breakthrough than by simultaneous pressure on the systems that allow conflict-affected societies and the global economy to continue functioning.

Sudan presents the clearest humanitarian deterioration. Reuters reported that July-September rainfall was the lowest in more than three decades nationwide, damaging crops and livestock while conflict continues to constrain markets and humanitarian access. WFP estimates drought could push another 350,000 people into severe hunger by the end of 2026 [1].

In the DRC, the Ebola outbreak expanded into an eighth province. By October 16, cumulative confirmed cases reached 9,415 with 4,536 deaths, while Ituri remained the principal recent hotspot. Cross-border preparedness is also becoming more urgent as infections have appeared outside the DRC [2,3].

The Ethiopia-Eritrea crisis remains unresolved. Federal military movement toward the Eritrean border has been followed by mediation efforts, but the underlying competition over Tigray, sovereignty, and regional security remains intact [6,7].

Ukraine experienced renewed missile pressure while concerns over warning, intelligence support, and U.S.-Ukraine political friction added a second layer of vulnerability beyond physical infrastructure [8,9].

The Middle East remains the highest systemic risk. Houthi attacks pushed oil prices to a five-month high, freight rates rose, refiners changed tanker and purchasing practices, and reported mine incidents in Hormuz reinforced the interaction among physical threat, insurance, shipping, and energy prices [10,11,12].

Taiwan's security environment also demonstrated that strategic competition extends beyond military formations. Taipei is investigating alleged organized-crime links to Chinese coercive activity while TSMC is seeking alternatives to rare-earth-dependent factory equipment, highlighting social and industrial dependency risks [13,14].

ANALYTIC JUDGMENT This week's core judgment: the most dangerous systems are those in which military, humanitarian, economic, information, and infrastructure stress are beginning to reinforce one another faster than institutions can compensate.

01 Key Judgments

- Sudan: High confidence that drought and war are converging into a deeper food-security emergency; humanitarian access and assistance funding are becoming decisive variables.
- DRC: High confidence that geographic spread and cross-border cases demonstrate incomplete epidemiological control; surveillance visibility remains a central uncertainty.
- Ethiopia-Eritrea: Moderate confidence that mediation can contain direct interstate escalation in the near term; the underlying drivers remain unresolved.
- Mozambique: No new corroborated threshold crossing. Standing assessment remains that ISM coercion, ransom, and rural mobility matter more than territorial headlines.
- Sahel: No new theater-wide inflection. JNIM's economic and cross-border influence remains the principal structural concern.
- Ukraine: High confidence physical infrastructure pressure is now compounded by warning, intelligence, and political-support uncertainty.
- Middle East: High confidence maritime-energy disruption is transmitting directly into oil, freight, and refinery behavior.

- Taiwan Strait: Moderate-high confidence coercion is increasingly multi-domain, spanning law enforcement, criminal networks, supply-chain pressure, information activity, and conventional deterrence.
- Europe: Moderate-high confidence drone incursions and civil unrest are expanding the security burden on civilian infrastructure and domestic governance.

02 Global Strategic Risk Dashboard

THEATER	RISK	DIRECTION	PRINCIPAL CONCERN
Middle East / Hormuz / Red Sea	**Critical**	↑	Maritime-energy disruption
Sudan	**Critical**	↑ ↑	War + drought + hunger
DRC	**Critical**	↑	Ebola geographic spread + conflict
Ukraine	**Critical**	↑	Infrastructure + warning-support uncertainty
Ethiopia-Eritrea	**Critical**	↔️	Contained but unresolved interstate risk
Sahel	**Critical**	↔️	Cross-border economic coercion
Mozambique	**High**	↔️	ISM mobility and ransom economy
Taiwan Strait	**High**	↑	Multi-domain coercion and dependency
Europe / hybrid security	**High**	↑	Drone defense and civil unrest

03 Sudan

War and Drought Converge Into a Food-System Emergency

FACT

Reuters reported Sudan's July-September rainfall was the lowest in more than 30 years. Crop and livestock losses are severe in Darfur, Kordofan, and Gedaref. WFP estimates drought could push another 350,000 people into severe hunger by the end of 2026 and 1.2 million more by August 2027 [1].

INTERPRETATION

The conflict is no longer only disrupting food access through violence. Climate shock is simultaneously reducing production, weakening livestock, and increasing dependence on humanitarian assistance that is itself underfunded and access-constrained.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

High confidence Sudan faces a compound war-food-climate crisis. Moderate-high confidence the risk of localized famine will rise where market disruption, displacement, and reduced aid intersect with crop failure.

INDICATORS

Harvest volumes; livestock condition; cereal prices; WFP ration size; access denials; displacement; market closures; rainfall and temperature anomalies.

04 Democratic Republic of the Congo

Ebola Expansion Tests Surveillance and Regional Preparedness

FACT

DRC confirmed spread into an eighth province, Nord-Ubangi, after two confirmed cases including one death. By October 16, cumulative confirmed cases stood at 9,415 with 4,536 deaths; Ituri accounted for 44 of 67 new cases reported in the prior 24 hours [2].

INTERPRETATION

Geographic expansion means aggregate national totals are an insufficient measure of control. The outbreak must be evaluated through transmission chains, surveillance coverage, border mobility, and local access.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

High confidence the outbreak remains uncontrolled at the national-system level. High confidence cross-border preparedness is now a regional security requirement [3].

ACH

H1 transmission continues to expand; H2 some geographic growth reflects improved detection; H3 transmission is shifting into areas with weaker surveillance. H1 and H3 can operate simultaneously.

05 Ethiopia-Eritrea-Tigray

Mediation Begins, Structural Drivers Remain

FACT

Ethiopian troops had advanced to a border town previously controlled by Tigrayan rebels, increasing fears of confrontation with Eritrea. By October 22, reporting indicated U.S.-linked mediation efforts seeking to manage the Ethiopia-Eritrea dispute [6,7].

INTERPRETATION

Mediation reduces immediate escalation pressure but does not resolve disputes over sovereignty, security buffers, political authority in Tigray, or Ethiopia's Red Sea aspirations.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

Moderate confidence direct interstate escalation can be contained during the next 30 days; low-moderate confidence existing diplomacy can produce durable settlement without addressing the underlying regional security architecture.

INDICATORS

Border deployments; diplomatic contacts; attacks near the frontier; Tigray administration legitimacy; displacement; Red Sea access rhetoric; Eritrean mobilization.

06 Mozambique

Standing Assessment: Coercion, Ransom, and Mobility

FACT

No sufficiently corroborated development between October 18 and 23 changes the standing assessment. ACLED's October monitor remains the strongest current synthesis, emphasizing civilian targeting, abductions, ransom, Nangade-Tanzania linkages, and access restrictions [4].

INTERPRETATION

The absence of a new headline event should not be interpreted as de-escalation. ISM's strategic value lies in maintaining mobility and coercive reach while forcing state and humanitarian actors to absorb security costs.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

Moderate-high confidence ISM retains operational flexibility; moderate confidence Niassa is becoming a recurring rather than permanent front.

TRIGGER

A second substantial Niassa operation combined with renewed ransom-linked abduction should trigger reassessment of a durable western operating corridor.

07 The Sahel

Standing Assessment: Economic Influence Beyond Territorial Control

FACT

No new theater-wide inflection during the reporting window justifies replacing the previous assessment. JNIM's western Mali entrenchment continues to expose Senegalese trade and mining networks [5].

INTERPRETATION

The key risk is not only cross-border attack. It is the diffusion of coercion through trade, gold, taxation, recruitment, and local relationships.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

High confidence economic influence can expand beyond areas of direct territorial control; moderate confidence Guinea and Senegal will experience rising pressure without necessarily becoming full operational theaters.

INDICATORS

Cross-border recruitment; extortion; market closures; gold-sector disruption; fuel access; verified attacks; road taxation; militant support networks.

08 Ukraine

Infrastructure Pressure Meets Warning and Support Uncertainty

FACT

A Russian ballistic-missile attack on October 19 struck Kyiv without advance warning from partners, according to Ukrainian officials [8]. Separately, Reuters reported a sharp political dispute between Washington and Kyiv over Ukrainian refinery strikes and broader support [9].

INTERPRETATION

Ukraine now faces two forms of recuperability risk: physical repair of damaged infrastructure and continuity of the external intelligence, communications, and political support that enables defense.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

High confidence infrastructure resilience remains central. Moderate-high confidence uncertainty over warning and external support can amplify the effects of Russian strike campaigns even without immediate changes in front-line geography.

INDICATORS

Warning time; air-defense intercept rates; satellite and intelligence continuity; power restoration; weapons deliveries; refinery-strike policy; sanctions changes.

09 Middle East

Physical Attacks Transmit Into Energy and Shipping Markets

FACT

Oil prices rose roughly 4% to a five-month high on October 22 as Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia increased supply concerns [10]. Asian refiners were already adapting to high freight rates by using smaller tankers and delivered-crude purchases [11]. Iran's Revolutionary Guards said two tankers caught fire after hitting mines in Hormuz on October 17 [12].

INTERPRETATION

The strategic effect of maritime insecurity is visible not only in attacks but in behavior: tanker selection, chartering, insurance, delivered-price premiums, refinery purchasing, and diplomatic evacuation decisions.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

High confidence Middle East maritime insecurity is generating measurable global economic adaptation. Moderate confidence current market effects remain reversible without a sustained reduction in security.

INDICATORS

Brent price; freight rates; tanker size and routing; war-risk premiums; vessel throughput; port delays; mine incidents; Houthi launch tempo; Saudi infrastructure damage.

10 Taiwan Strait

Coercion Extends Into Society and Supply Chains

FACT

Taiwan is investigating alleged organized-crime links to Chinese “transnational repression” [13]. TSMC is exploring alternatives to rare-earth components in factory equipment to reduce dependency exposure [14].

INTERPRETATION

The Taiwan security problem includes social coercion and industrial dependency alongside conventional military deterrence. Vulnerability can be generated through influence networks and supply-chain concentration without a blockade or invasion.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

Moderate-high confidence Beijing’s coercive toolkit is multi-domain. High confidence semiconductor resilience depends partly on substitution capacity for specialized industrial inputs.

INDICATORS

Criminal-network cases; influence operations; supply-chain concentration; rare-earth availability; maritime pressure; cyber incidents; military exercise geography.

11 Emerging Strategic Flashpoint

Europe: Civilian Infrastructure Becomes Part of the Security Perimeter

FACT

European governments are considering expanded authority for utilities and infrastructure operators to counter drones [15]. A suspected drone exploded over Lithuania after triggering shelter warnings [16]. France also experienced major unrest linked to cost-of-living and political grievances [17].

INTERPRETATION

Europe’s security burden is broadening from military defense toward protection of civilian infrastructure, airspace, public order, and economic resilience.

QAP ANALYTIC JUDGMENT

Moderate-high confidence hybrid and domestic-security pressures will increasingly converge around critical infrastructure and public confidence.

INDICATORS

Airspace incursions; infrastructure drone events; emergency alerts; counter-drone legal changes; protest violence; transport disruption; disinformation around incidents.

12 CARVER Strategic Vulnerability Assessment

Higher scores indicate greater vulnerability. For Recuperability, higher scores mean more difficult recovery. Rz denotes Recognizability. These theater-level scores prioritize analysis and are not operational targeting assessments.

SYSTEM	C	A	R	V	E	Rz	TOTAL
Hormuz-Red Sea energy/shipping	5	5	5	5	5	5	**30**
Sudan food-humanitarian system	5	4	5	5	5	4	**28**
DRC surveillance-health system	5	4	5	5	5	4	**28**
Ukraine infrastructure/warning system	5	4	5	5	5	4	**28**
Ethiopia-Eritrea regional security	5	4	5	4	5	4	**27**
Taiwan semiconductor-maritime system	5	3	5	4	5	5	**27**
Sahel trade-governance network	5	4	4	4	5	4	**26**
Mozambique access-security system	4	4	4	4	4	4	**24**

CARVER FINDING This week the key CARVER refinement is dependency concentration. A system becomes strategically fragile when essential functions depend on nodes or inputs that cannot be substituted quickly.

13 Root Cause Analysis / Conflict Prevention & Stabilization (RCA/CPS)

Sudan

Root causes now intersect directly with climate exposure: militarized political economy, displacement, market fragmentation, weak institutions, drought, and constrained aid. Prevention priority: keep food, market, and humanitarian corridors functioning. Stabilization must restore legitimate economic exchange, agricultural production, services, and civilian protection.

DRC

Conflict fragmentation and distrust weaken epidemic control. Prevention priority: preserve cross-line surveillance and border preparedness. Stabilization requires trusted local health networks, treatment access, mobility monitoring, and reliable reporting.

Ethiopia-Eritrea

Historical distrust, sovereignty disputes, unresolved Tigray governance, and Red Sea competition remain key drivers. Prevention priority: maintain deconfliction and mediation. Stabilization depends on legitimate Tigray governance and a workable regional security arrangement.

Mozambique

Rural exclusion, weak justice, uneven development, and insurgent coercion remain structural. Prevention should disrupt ransom and recruitment networks without creating additional civilian grievances. Stabilization must connect security to local economic and institutional legitimacy.

Sahel

Weak rural governance, civilian harm, informal economies, and cross-border militant finance remain key. Prevention should protect trade and mining corridors while improving local legitimacy and justice.

Ukraine

The conflict now tests both physical and alliance-system resilience. Stabilization requires infrastructure redundancy plus continuity of warning, intelligence, and external support necessary for civilian defense.

Middle East

The central risk is multi-node maritime-energy dependency. Prevention should preserve navigability and reduce attacks on civilian transport and energy systems. Monitoring must include market behavior, not only attack counts.

Taiwan

The core issue is coercive dependency across maritime access, semiconductors, information, and social networks. Prevention should reduce concentrated dependencies and improve lawful resilience against gray-zone coercion.

RCA/CPS CROSS-THEATER FINDING Fragility becomes strategically dangerous when disruption accumulates faster than legitimate institutions and communities can absorb, adapt, substitute, and recover.

14 Signals, Escalation & Warning Dashboard

THEATER	RISK	DIRECTION	PRINCIPAL CONCERN
Sudan	**Critical**	↑	Harvest collapse + ration cuts + access loss
DRC	**Critical**	↑	New province + cross-border cases
Ethiopia-Eritrea	**Critical**	↔	Mediation failure or border strikes
Ukraine	**Critical**	↑	Warning/support interruption + infrastructure strikes
Middle East	**Critical**	↑	Mine/tanker incidents + oil/freight spike
Taiwan	**High**	↑	Coercive networks + supply-chain pressure
Mozambique	**High**	↔	Repeat Niassa + ransom abductions
Sahel	**High-Critical**	↔	Economic coercion crosses borders
Europe	**High**	↑	Drone incidents + public-order stress

15 Analyst's Notebook

Key assumptions: Sudan's drought impacts persist into the harvest cycle; DRC surveillance captures only part of true transmission; Ethiopia-Eritrea mediation remains active; ISM retains mobility without durable Niassa administration; JNIM economic influence remains greater than its coastal-state territorial reach;

U.S.-Ukraine support remains uncertain but not fully severed; Houthi and Iranian maritime capabilities remain sufficient for continued disruption; China continues to prefer coercion below invasion if effective.

Priority intelligence gaps: Sudan crop and market data; DRC unlinked chains and border surveillance; Eritrean force posture; ISM financing and Tanzania links; JNIM trade and gold coercion; Ukraine warning/intelligence continuity; Hormuz mine attribution and vessel reporting completeness; Taiwan industrial substitution timelines and coercive-network reach.

16 Strategic Outlook

30-Day Outlook

Sudan and DRC will dominate humanitarian-system risk. Middle East energy and shipping costs are likely to remain elevated. Ethiopia-Eritrea diplomacy may contain immediate interstate escalation, but unresolved drivers persist. Ukraine will face continued infrastructure pressure with uncertainty over warning and support. Confidence: Moderate-High.

90-Day Outlook

The main tests will be Sudan's harvest and aid trajectory, whether DRC transmission slows across newly affected provinces, the durability of Horn mediation, repeat ISM activity in Niassa, JNIM economic pressure on coastal neighbors, and whether Middle East maritime insecurity normalizes or becomes structurally embedded in freight and insurance costs. Confidence: Moderate.

180-Day Outlook

Managed Competitive Instability remains plausible. Cascading Regional Escalation is the highest-consequence pathway if Sudan's food system collapses further, DRC loses surveillance control, Horn mediation fails, or maritime-energy disruption becomes chronic. Selective De-escalation requires simultaneous improvement in access, surveillance, diplomacy, and infrastructure resilience. These are qualitative structured scenarios.

17 Bottom Line

The week ending October 24 reinforces a central QAP principle: instability becomes most dangerous when the visible event is only the surface expression of a deeper dependency problem. Sudan's drought amplifies war because food systems lack redundancy. DRC's outbreak becomes regional because surveillance and border systems are fragmented. Ukraine's physical infrastructure is more vulnerable when warning and external support are uncertain. Maritime attacks affect the global economy because shipping, insurance, refining, and energy prices are tightly coupled. Taiwan's resilience depends partly on whether industrial and social dependencies can be substituted before coercion exploits them.

BOTTOM LINE The next analytical question is not only what can be disrupted, but what cannot be substituted quickly enough when disruption occurs.

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